Good Pupils

By Jack Lothian

On Monday, David's desk is still empty. We've gone through the same process that we go through every day: lining up, trudging through the metal detectors, bags on the conveyor belt, random searches that never feel that random. Picking up our collars from the tray at the end, putting them on. Through another set of metal detectors into the room, and then to the desk, and the whole time I didn't want to look to my right, didn't want to see his seat, as if by not looking, it'll somehow break the jinx. David will be slouched there, scowling, like it was a normal Monday. But the seat is empty, because of what happened last week.

INTRODUCTION

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David and I grew up on the same street before his father lost his job and they had to relocate to cheaper housing. I'd been best friends with David since we were

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six, almost ten years now. I couldn't care less where he lived. [He is . . . was] an ally in this world, someone who has your back, no matter what.

Our big guilty pleasure: old teen movies. Breakfast Club, Ridgemont High, Heathers, Grease . . . I get they're corny, and the clothes are weird and the music bad, but they've got a strange energy and spirit. In Dead Poet's Society they stand on their desks. My desk has my name printed on it and is bolted to the ground. When Bender tells Mr. Vernon to 'eat his shorts', it's amazing to see someone talk to a teacher like that, and not end up on their knees as a result, drooling and disoriented.

DAVID: *(laughing)* These are not good pupils.

The problem with David is that he's not really a good pupil either. He's a smart ass, likes to talk back, and even when he's not speaking he's got an array of tuts and snorts he can deploy to signify displeasure at whoever is talking. When we started in Mr. Garvey's class, it was clear that David's prime motivation was to test the limits of our new teacher, day by day, lesson by

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lesson. He's also smart though, in a way I don't think I could ever be. He looks at equations or math problems, and something in that brain of his just clicks.

So when they introduced the collars, I could see his eyes light up. I knew he'd eventually find a way to slip one out from school, take into his garage, and dissect it. *(Pause)*

It's been three months since I've seen anyone collared. I don't know the exact details of the incident. All I know is what I saw. He was shouting at Mr. Phillips, gesturing, spit flying from his mouth, some argument they'd got into. He picked up a trash can to throw it. At that moment Mr. Phillips gave a verbal command, and the kid just dropped. His body spasmed and shook.

Security took him away, and it was a few weeks until he was allowed back. He's okay now. Sits quiet. Does his work. Never asks questions in class, but never disrupts either. Definitely what they call a "good pupil."

The collars had been part of our everyday school life for over a year when David finally sneaked one out. He laid it down on the bench and started taking it apart.

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He stripped out the metal work, showing me the tiny motherboard, which he said controls both the shock and the voice trigger.

DAVID: Easy enough to smuggle it out of school. Smuggling it back in-that's the challenge!

He'd been engaged in an on-going debate with Mr. Garvey for weeks, something to do with amendments and rights. You can tell Mr. Garvey can't stand David. I don't blame him. When David thinks he's right, he gets this tone in his voice, like he pities you for not being able to keep up. Like it's not enough for him to be right, but he's got to humiliate you as well.

He reached into his drawer and rummaged around, taking out a pair of scissors.

DAVID: Cut my hair

ME: I'm not a hairdresser, dumbo.

DAVID: I know that, dumbo. That's why I want you to do it. Just chop away. I want Garvey to look at me and think, 'What is wrong with that kid.'

So I hacked off a clump. David smiled as the hair tumbled into his lap.

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You could see security giving him odd looks when he came in the next day. This was the day he decided to smuggle the dismantled collar back in, looping it round the handle of his bag, so you could barely notice. His hair was lopsided. He'd ended up shaving one side as well, then stopping before it was complete. It gave the impression of someone who'd staggered out of a medieval asylum.

"You look like a freak," I whispered before I filed through the metal detector ahead of him.

On that day he sidetracked Garvey into an argument on rights. David said the exercise of your rights cannot infringe on another person's. Garvey leaped on that, and they went round and round, until David pointed out that he was quoting something Garvey had said a few weeks before, so either it still held true, or Garvey didn't know what he's talking about.

MR. GARVEY: You will apologize.

DAVID: *(dripping with sarcasm)* I'm sorry. I'm sorry that you don't know what the *** you're talking about!

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David then started recounting the plot of The Breakfast Club as if it was a historical documentary, drawing special attention to the scene where the kids ran free through the halls.

DAVID: Have you ever stopped to think about what that meant, about what all we've sacrificed!

David was moving towards the blackboard when Garvey gave the verbal command to activate the collar. David's body jerked. He staggered forward and there was an audible gasp in class. You could tell some people were horrified, and some were secretly excited to see a collar going off. David stumbled forward a few more steps, and his arms flew out, like a marionette with its strings all tangled . . . Then he raised his head and smiled at our teacher.

DAVID: Mr. Garvey? Go eat my shorts. *(takes off the modified collar and throws it to the ground) (Pause)*

There's that scene in the movies where everyone starts spontaneously applauding at once. That's exactly what happened as David walked out of the room. Even the kids who couldn't stand him were banging on their

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desks, hollering. Mr. Garvey just stood there, staring at us, like we were animals in a zoo, and the bars weren't as solid as he thought.

A week passed. David was absent. His parents didn't pick up the phone. My mother sat me down for "a talk." She told me he's a bad influence. She said if I wanted to do well in life, go to a good college and have a career, then I needed to stay away from [people] like that.

David returned on Tuesday. His head has been completely shaved. He is pale, and he walks with a slow and deliberate gait. He doesn't look at me. He sits at his desk, a fresh collar on, his hands folded. He copies down notes. He listens when other kids ask questions. He repeats back the phrases that Mr. Garvey tells us to.

He never disagrees. He never rolls his eyes at something Garvey says. His eyes are vacant lots, where once there used to be cities on fire. Something inside me breaks.

ME: What's wrong with David, sir?

MR. GARVEY: *(turns from the blackboard to answer. Smiles)* Nothing.

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ME: *(louder)* What's wrong with David, sir?

I know I can keep asking forever, until the school crumbles and falls, and I'll still never get a proper answer from him. I think of those kids in the movies, running in the corridors. Standing on desks. Getting high behind the bleachers. Breaking into the school at night. I think of glorious, wild, untamed youth.

I am already out of my seat and running for Mr. Garvey. I think I'm shouting, "What's wrong with David?" but I'm not entirely sure anymore. Mr. Garvey is yelling the command, and pain rips through my neck, yet still my legs are moving, and my hands are out. That's when Mr. Garvey reaches for his gun and pulls the trigger.

They tell me I'm lucky. The bullet grazed my skull. *(Long pause)* They were going to open it up anyway. *(Long pause)*

(with no emotion or affect) I can name all the States. I can tell you that John Hancock put the first signature on the Declaration of Independence. I know that the tallest mountain is McKinley. I can't tell you what that

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anger feels like though anymore, that helpless rage. I can't watch those movies either. They seem jumbled and strange, like a language I'll never learn.

I sit next to David in class. We nod, and we copy down answers, and we listen intently to what the teacher says. We are good pupils, just like they wanted us to be.

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